

THE HOLLOW DIALOGUE DIAGNOSTIC

A six-check scan for the scene that reads correctly and lands flat.

Something happens when you read a character who has no wound underneath. You finish the scene, you move on, but something in you quietly disengaged. Readers feel a missing substrate before they can name it — they just call it something else: the pacing was slow, the dialogue felt flat, I couldn't get into it.

Pull up one scene from your current draft. Run it through the six checks below. You're not looking for a better line — you're looking for where the protective instinct is missing.

1 The Say-What-They-Mean Test

Read each line of dialogue and ask: does this character say exactly what they feel, with nothing held back? Real people under pressure deflect, protect, and circle. If every line lands on-target with no evasion, the scene is managing information instead of behaving like a person.

2 The Swap Test

Cover the character names. Could any other character in your manuscript speak these same lines without it reading wrong? If the dialogue survives the swap, it isn't coming from a specific person — it's coming from the plot's need for information to be exchanged.

3 The Silence Audit

Count what the character doesn't say. Flat dialogue tends to answer every question fully. Living dialogue leaves gaps — a question dodged, a subject changed, a sentence left unfinished. If there's no unspoken residue after the exchange, something is missing underneath it.

4 The Protection Check

For each line, ask: what would this cost the character to say honestly? If you can't answer — if nothing is at stake in the saying of it — the line has no protective instinct behind it, and protective instinct is what makes speech sound human rather than expository.

5 The Craft-Fix Trap

Notice if your instinct is to fix the line itself — sharper word choice, better rhythm, a punchier exchange. Surface polish on a hollow line produces a cleaner hollow line. If the fix you're reaching for only touches the words, you're treating a symptom, not the missing substrate.

6 The Read-Aloud Tell

Read the exchange out loud. Flat dialogue sounds correct. Living dialogue sounds like someone who has something to protect — even if you can't yet name what that something is. Trust the flatness in your own voice before you trust your eye on the page.

If your scene fails three or more checks:

That's not a rewriting problem. It's a missing-substrate problem — and no amount of line-level polish will fix it. The Stratum Socratic Writing Method walks you through excavating what your character is actually protecting, so the next draft doesn't just sound better. It's built on something real.